Lightning withdrawal record

Two withdrawals from the Altradits LND node to Wallet of Satoshi, Sunday 8 November 2026 (EAT). Every step, including the attempts that failed, and why no money was at risk.

Result

68,300 sats withdrawn in two payments (about $51.79 / KSh 6,729 at $75,832 per BTC), for 87.74 sats in fees. That is the maximum the node can send while its channel stays open.

	Withdrawal 1	Withdrawal 2
Sent	**30,000 sats**	**38,300 sats**
Routing fee	38.66 sats	49.08 sats
Time (EAT)	11:55, settled in 10 s	12:05, settled in 16 s
Route	Peer A -> Nova -> kappa	Peer A -> Nova -> kappa
Payment hash	[64-character ID]	[64-character ID]
Proof of payment (preimage)	[64-character ID]	[64-character ID]

The preimage is the receipt: only the recipient could have revealed it, so it proves the payment arrived. It is safe to keep in this record. The channel is still open and active.

Balances before and after

	Start	After 1 (12:01)	After 2 (12:07)	Change
Your side of the channel	97,974	67,936	29,587	-68,387
Reserve (locked while open)	29,434	29,434	29,434	0
Spendable	68,540	38,502	153	-68,387
Can receive	2,844,236	2,874,274	2,912,623	+68,387
On-chain wallet	0	0	0	0

All figures in sats, read from the node, which rounds millisatoshis. The 153 sats left above the reserve are too few to be worth routing.

Step by step

Step 1. Work out how much can be withdrawn (before 11:44)

```
~/bin/lncli --lnddir=$HOME/.lnd-altradits --network=mainnet \
  --macaroonpath=$HOME/.lnd-altradits/data/chain/bitcoin/mainnet/readonly.macaroon \
  listchannels | grep -E 'local_balance|chan_reserve_sat'
```

97,974 on your side minus the 29,434-sat reserve = 68,540 spendable. Keeping room for fees, the safe maximum was 67,500 sats. The on-chain wallet was empty, so the withdrawal had to go over Lightning.

Step 2. Create an invoice in Wallet of Satoshi (11:44)

Receive, amount 67,500 sats, copy the invoice (starts with `lnbc`). An invoice can only receive, so it is safe to share.

```
lnbc... (the invoice from your wallet)
```

Step 3. Check the invoice before paying (11:45)

Decoded with the read-only key, which can't spend anything:

```
~/bin/lncli --lnddir=$HOME/.lnd-altradits --network=mainnet \
  --macaroonpath=$HOME/.lnd-altradits/data/chain/bitcoin/mainnet/readonly.macaroon \
  decodepayreq <invoice>
~/bin/lncli --lnddir=$HOME/.lnd-altradits --network=mainnet \
  --macaroonpath=$HOME/.lnd-altradits/data/chain/bitcoin/mainnet/readonly.macaroon \
  queryroutes --dest <destination> --amt 67500
```

Amount 67,500 sats, mainnet, valid 24 hours, recipient node "kappa" (Wallet of Satoshi receives through a provider's node). A route existed for a 14-sat fee.

Step 4. First attempt: wrong key (about 11:48)

Using `router.macaroon` failed at once with *verification failed: signature mismatch*. That file was left over from an older setup and no longer matched the node's keys. Nothing was sent. The full-access key LND made at the morning restart was used instead.

Step 5. Second attempt: 67,500 sats timed out (11:50)

```
~/bin/lncli --lnddir=$HOME/.lnd-altradits --network=mainnet \
  payinvoice --fee_limit 500 <invoice>      # type yes in full
```

Three routes were tried in 60 seconds. Peer A's own channel to kappa didn't have room for 67,500 sats, and the two longer routes went through nodes Peer A is no longer connected to (the node's map was out of date). Result: FAILED, timeout, **0 sats sent**, balance unchanged.

A failed Lightning payment can't lose money: every hop is locked to the same secret, so either the whole payment completes or every hop is cancelled.

Step 6. Smaller invoice (11:53)

Smaller payments find room more easily. A new 30,000-sat invoice from Wallet of Satoshi, checked the same way: same recipient, 30,000 sats, valid 24 hours.

```
lnbc... (the invoice from your wallet)
```

Step 7. Third attempt: 30,000 sats succeeded (11:55)

```
~/bin/lncli --lnddir=$HOME/.lnd-altradits --network=mainnet \
  payinvoice --fee_limit 300 --timeout 5m <invoice>
```

Try	Route	Outcome
1	Peer A -> kappa	Peer A's channel too full
2	Peer A -> 21M node -> kappa	Fee too low for that node, retried
3	Peer A -> Nova -> kappa	Fee too low, retried higher
4	Peer A -> Nova -> kappa	**SUCCEEDED**, fee 38.66 sats, 10 seconds

Step 8. Confirm on the node (12:01)

```
~/bin/lncli --lnddir=$HOME/.lnd-altradits --network=mainnet \
  --macaroonpath=$HOME/.lnd-altradits/data/chain/bitcoin/mainnet/readonly.macaroon \
  listpayments --include_incomplete
~/bin/lncli --lnddir=$HOME/.lnd-altradits --network=mainnet \
  --macaroonpath=$HOME/.lnd-altradits/data/chain/bitcoin/mainnet/readonly.macaroon \
  listchannels | grep -E 'local_balance|remote_balance'
```

Payment SUCCEEDED, your side down to 67,936 sats, channel still active.

Step 9. Work out the maximum for the second withdrawal (12:03)

67,936 on your side minus the 29,434 reserve = 38,502 spendable. The node's route quote was 49 sats, so the invoice was set at **38,300 sats** with a 200-sat fee cap (38,300 + 200 = 38,500).

The Wallet of Satoshi invoice came without an amount (an open-amount invoice). That works: the amount is set when paying, with `--amt`.

Step 10. Fourth attempt: 38,300 sats succeeded first time (12:05)

```
~/bin/lncli --lnddir=$HOME/.lnd-altradits --network=mainnet \
  payinvoice --amt 38300 --fee_limit 200 --timeout 5m <invoice>
```

The node went straight to the route that worked before (Peer A -> Nova -> kappa), because it remembers which routes succeed. Fee 49.08 sats, settled in 16 seconds.

Step 11. Confirm on the node (12:07)

Payment SUCCEEDED. Your side is down to 29,587 sats: the 29,434-sat reserve plus 153 sats. Nothing more can usefully be sent while the channel is open.

What is left, and why

29,587 sats stay in the channel. 29,434 of them are the reserve: 1% of the channel that Lightning keeps on each side so that cheating would always cost something. They are still yours and come back to the node's on-chain wallet if the channel ever closes. Closing it to get them now would end the 2.9M sats of receiving capacity bought from Magma, so it isn't worth it.

Receiving went up. The node can now receive 2,912,623 sats on altradits.com, up from 2,844,236.

Still to do

Check Wallet of Satoshi shows 30,000 sats at 11:55 and 38,300 sats at 12:05.

Delete the keys used today. The full-access key was needed to send; delete it and the stale router key. LND makes fresh copies at its next restart.

```
rm ~/.lnd-altradits/data/chain/bitcoin/mainnet/admin.macaroon \
   ~/.lnd-altradits/data/chain/bitcoin/mainnet/router.macaroon
```

Ignore the old 67,500-sat invoice. It was never paid and expires by itself at 11:44 on 9 November.

Next time, in short

1. Check spendable: your side minus the reserve. 2. Make the invoice in Wallet of Satoshi (an open amount is fine). 3. Decode it with the read-only key (decodepayreq). 4. Pay with `payinvoice --amt <sats> --fee_limit 200 --timeout 5m` and type **yes**. If the full amount fails, try a smaller one. 5. Confirm on the node and delete the full-access key.